JAPANESE-KOREAN WAR

Japanese leader Toyotomi Hideyoshi's first step toward fulfilling his ambition of conquering China was to invade Korea. In 1592 he shipped a large army to Pusan, the port closest to Japan across the Tsushima Strait. Japanese land forces made rapid progress northward, but their seaborne supply lines were always vulnerable and the invasion was called off in 1593. When the Japanese returned in 1597, they conquered less territory on land and again suffered crucial defeats at the hands of Yi Sunshin's navy.

KEY

- Japan
- Korea
- Area of Korea occupied by Japanese forces
- Japanese invasion route
- Korean victory
- Japanese victory





Korean naval cannon
Usually mounted on wheeled wooden carriages, Korean cannons fired a range of projectiles, including solid shot, fragmentation bombs, and incendiary "fireballs." Some longer cannons fired giant arrows with iron tips.

fighting, Japanese raiders traditionally employed swift-moving boats crammed with warriors, who would board and overwhelm larger, slower-moving craft. The larger Japanese ships would also be packed with fighting men, armed with missile weapons to soften up the enemy, prior to boarding and fighting with sword and spear. One striking advantage the Japanese held over the Koreans was the possession of firearms. The arquebus, the precursor of the matchlock musket, which had been introduced by the Portuguese, was enthusiastically adopted by the Japanese during their 16th-century civil wars. Deployed at sea, it was a highly effective complement to traditional bows. But the Japanese lacked larger gunpowder weapons. They had lagged behind China and Korea in the development of cannon, and their ships were in any case too flimsy and unstable to provide a good platform for guns.

KOREAN VICTORY

The Koreans had learned the use of gunpowder weapons from Ming China, but they had quickly surpassed the Chinese in the manufacture of cannon for naval use. By the late 16th century they had the most advanced shipborne artillery in Asia. Their key warship, the *panokseon*, was a robustly constructed ship that functioned as a stable gun platform. It carried cannon capable of delivering a variety of missiles, including gunpowder-based incendiary devices known as "fireballs." While Japanese ships had only square sails, the *panokseon* could be propelled by oars in combat, giving it impressive speed and maneuverability. With an admiral of genius in charge, Yi Sunshin, the Koreans repeatedly outmaneuvered and outfought the Japanese. Yi Sunshin used local knowledge of currents, tides, and winds to gain a huge advantage for his ships, even in situations where they were vastly outnumbered by the enemy.

JAPAN TURNS INWARD

Although its invasions of Korea were defeated at sea, it still seemed that Japan might emerge as an Asian naval power. The Japanese had galleons built under European influence in the early 17th century, one of which carried a Japanese embassy to Europe. But like Ming China before it, Japan then turned its back decisively on oceanic travel. It is said that, by order of the Japanese shoguns, all ships had to be built with a hole in the hull so as not to survive an ocean voyage. Japan's next foray into naval history was not until the 19th century.

Korean turtle ship in action at Hansando
Yi Sunshin's most spectacular victory over the Japanese was at Hansando in August 1592. Cannon and fire arrows wrought incredible destruction among the enemy ships, of which 47 were destroyed, while the Koreans lost none.

